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1 Mount the blank between centres. I use a multi-head centre and use the cup, or ring, centre for this part of the process. The ring centre serves two purposes which are of benefit over a more conventional cone centre: firstly, unlike a cone centre, the ring centre will not split the wood along the grain, and is therefore a safer option for holding stock. Secondly, the indent that the ring produces is a useful aid when re-mounting a blank as it gives an exact reference point for realigning the blank later

2 Rough down the blank using a long-grind bowl gouge or spindle roughing gouge. Check for faults in the wood as you progress and if you find any you may need to remount to remove them. Try to keep the cylinder parallel

3 Turn an accurate tenon on the tailstock end of the blank. Your particular scroll chuck will have specific dimensions for this; note these dimensions and get in to the habit of making each tenon accurate to these dimensions. Remember that depth as well as diameter is important. Here you will see that a fault was noted on my blank. I marked beyond the fault so that I could cut it away later

4 Now re-mount the blank in the scroll chuck using the tenon to hold it. Bring up the tailstock for added support. Now mark 45mm in from the end of the blank. Using either the bowl gouge or spindle gouge begin to turn the top section, or 'umbrella', down. The first 15–20mm of the edge should be relatively flat, after which you can produce a raised boss. This section should be about 15mm deep

5 The remaining 30mm section needs to be turned down to a cylinder about 20mm diameter. From this turn a small decorative finial. I prefer a ball type finial but you may prefer something a little more ornate. Using a skew chisel will give you a far better finish on lignum but if you prefer, then use the spindle gouge

6 Using the point of a small parting and beading tool, cut 'V' cuts 3mm in from the edge and 13mm in from the edge. You can also cut one near the base of your finial. Take a small piece of Formica and scorch these cuts until black. Now you need to abrade this top section to a finish. Abrade from start grit to 400 grit, then seal with cellulose sealer

7 The umbrella needs to be about 3–4mm thick. Using either a spindle gouge or a parting tool, cut in to set this thickness for the first 10–20mm of depth

8 Now begin to remove waste working towards the centre of the blank. Be careful not to let the wings of the gouge catch. When space becomes tight remove waste from the left and work down. When the central section gets to about 30mm diameter stop cutting for now

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